Out of sheer curiosity, I asked a few journalists I knew what the fish basket was all about. One of them told me that it was a clever prop, invented by a Malayalam newspaper reporter to link Kurien Kalathil, my erstwhile prospective business partner in shrimp farming that never happened. Less imaginative reporters tried their skills at voyeurism. 'If the story is not strong, make it steamy,' seemed to be the editorial dictum in many Malayalam newsrooms.

Even the closest of my people might have thought that I would be feeling relatively better after I was released from jail; only I knew what I was going through. After the initial shock and insults while in the custody of the Kerala Police and IB, I was numbed into sleep many nights while in CBI custody and later in Viyyur Jail. Now the uncertainty kept me sleepless at night; even if I got a couple of hours of disturbed sleep in the wee hours, I woke up to another dawn of ridicule.

I might have felt better if I cried, but often sadness was overtaken by anger. Then helplessness. When you swirl in such a rapid interplay of emotions, you see a black hole were your sanity appears to be heading to. And it is easy to give up.

One morning after a sleepless night, I called up Narasimhan, a senior lawyer in Trivandrum and a friend of mine.

'Can you help me write my will?' I asked.

'Why now?'

'It has to be written someday. Why not now?

'Tell me one argument I have won against you,' he joked.

He agreed to get the will ready soon.

After a few days when Narasimhan rang up, it was Geetha, my daughter, who answered the phone. When the lawyer said that my will was ready to be collected, Geetha got the message.

Soon she and my son Sankar were in front of me.

'So, you want to commit suicide?' she said.

I sat silent, my face in my palm.

While in the custody of the IB, living with insults and staring at uncertainty, I had once thought about suicide, but soon realised the folly of